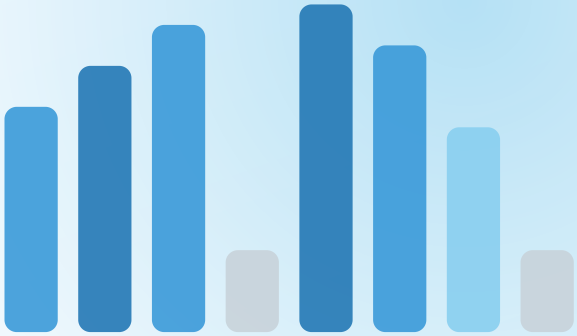
Ascend Coaching



MY PERSONAL TRAINING SPLIT

The exact split I train with: every day, every exercise, set and rep, plus how I warm up, progress and deload.

ASCEND COACHING GUIDE · 2026 EDITION

General fitness education, not medical advice. Check with your doctor before starting a new training program if you have an injury or medical condition. Information current as of November 2026.

CHAPTER 1

01 How my training evolved

For the majority of my journey I ran Push, Pull, Legs. Today I train a split that gives every muscle group its own focus, plus a full day for arms.

Where I started: Push, Pull, Legs

PPL built most of my physique. It's simple, it hits everything, and it's still what I'd recommend if you're in your first year or two of lifting. (My Recomp Blueprint lays out the PPL version.)

What I run now

Chest with biceps, back with triceps, shoulders and abs, legs, and a dedicated arm day, Monday to Friday, with weekends off. Every session is heavy: 3 sets of 6 to 8 reps on the main lifts.

CHAPTER 1 · THE SPLIT

The “bro split”

What this split is called

This is a **body-part split**, better known in the gym as a **“bro split”**. It’s the classic bodybuilding setup: each session focuses on one or two muscle groups and hits them hard from several angles. My version pairs each big muscle with a small one that isn’t already tired from the big lifts (chest with biceps, back with triceps), and adds a dedicated arm day. Bro splits are known for big pumps, a lot of focused volume per muscle and long-term physique building.

Why lifters switch from PPL to a split like this

- **More focus per muscle.** A whole session on chest or back means more sets and angles for that muscle while you’re fresh, instead of squeezing it in after other lifts.
- **Bringing up weak points.** A dedicated arm day and shoulder day give smaller muscles the attention they rarely get on PPL.
- **More recovery per muscle.** As you get stronger, heavy sessions beat you up more. Training each muscle hard once and then resting it longer suits heavy 6 to 8 rep work.
- **Fresh motivation.** After years of the same split, a change in structure makes training exciting again, and consistency is what drives results.

> **The trade-off:** on a bro split, most muscles are trained directly once a week instead of twice. Research shows that when total weekly sets are equal, how often you train a muscle makes little difference, so the key is getting enough hard sets in each session. That’s why this split works best for experienced lifters who can push every set.

Who this split is for

- **Great fit:** you’ve trained consistently for a year or more, you can train 5 days a week, and you want more focus and volume on each muscle group.
- **Not yet:** if you’re brand new, start with a full-body or PPL plan first. You’ll grow faster training each muscle more often while you learn the lifts.
- **Short on time?** Chapter 7 shows how to cut it down to 4 days.

CHAPTER 2

02 The split at a glance

Five lifting days, Monday to Friday, with your weekends off. Abs and cardio fit into the week, so Saturday and Sunday stay free.

MON	TUE	WED	THU	FRI	SAT	SUN
Chest + biceps	**Back** + triceps	**Shoulders** + abs + stairs	**Legs**	**Arms** + abs	**Rest** walk	**Rest** walk

Why it’s laid out in this order

- **Chest comes first,** after two days off, so your heaviest pressing day is your freshest.
- **Legs sit between shoulders and arms,** so your triceps get a day off after overhead pressing before arm day.
- **Biceps are paired with chest and triceps with back,** so the small muscle you train directly isn’t already tired from the big lifts that day.
- **The StairMaster cooldown goes after shoulders on Wednesday,** a short, easy finisher that won’t take anything away from Thursday’s legs.

Rest days aren’t lazy days

Your weekends off give your muscles and joints time to recover from heavy sets. But you still do something productive: a walk outside or 20 to 30 minutes on the treadmill. Aim for 8,000 to 10,000 steps every day.

EDWIN’S TIP

Even on my rest days I still try to do something productive, whether it’s walking on the treadmill or going on a walk outside. Rest from lifting doesn’t mean doing nothing.

CHAPTER 3

03 How to train every session

Heavy, controlled and focused. Three hard sets of 6 to 8 reps on almost every exercise, and every one of them counts.

MAIN LIFTS

3 × 6–8

Heavy enough that 8 reps is a real fight.

THE EXCEPTIONS

3 × 10–15

Abs, calves, lateral raises and rear delt flys. Small muscles that respond best to strict, higher reps.

REST BETWEEN SETS

2–3 min

On heavy lifts. 60 to 90 seconds on isolation moves.

Why 6 to 8 reps

Research shows muscle grows across a wide range of reps as long as sets are taken close to failure. Heavier sets of 6 to 8 add something extra: they build more strength. That makes 6 to 8 a sweet spot for getting bigger and stronger at the same time.

EDWIN'S TIP

3 sets of 6 to 8 heavy reps is how I train. In my opinion it's great for muscle growth and for getting stronger at the same time.

Effort

Finish each set with about 1 to 2 good reps left in the tank. Your last set of an exercise can go to failure on machines and cables, but avoid grinding to failure on heavy squats, bench or rows without a spotter.

CHAPTER 3 · SESSION EXTRAS

Drop sets and warm-ups

Drop sets

Exercises marked `+ drop set` in Chapter 4 get one on the **3rd set only**:

1. **Finish your 3rd set**
   Hit your reps as normal.
2. **Instantly drop the weight**
   No rest. Pull the pin or grab the lighter dumbbells right away and take off about 25 to 30% of the weight.
3. **Rep it out**
   Do as many clean reps as you can, stopping when your form starts to break.

Only use drop sets on machines, cables and dumbbells, never on heavy barbell squats, bench or deadlifts. Research shows drop sets build about as much muscle as extra regular sets, in less time.

> **EDWIN'S TIP**
>
> I love drop sets. When you finish a hard 3rd set, the muscle isn't actually done. It just can't move that weight anymore. Instantly dropping the weight lets you keep working it close to failure with no rest, so you squeeze extra growth-driving reps out of the same set in less time, and the pump is unreal. Save them for the last set of an exercise so they don't drain the rest of your workout.

How I warm up

Before my first heavy lift, I warm up with a simple compound movement for the muscle I'm training: dips on triceps days, pull-ups on back day. Each workout in Chapter 4 lists one. Do 2 easy sets of it, stopping well short of failure.

Then do a few lighter ramp-up sets of your first exercise until you feel warmed up and the blood is flowing, before your 3 heavy sets.

CHAPTER 3 · SESSION EXTRAS

Fuel your workouts

EDWIN'S TIP

Carb up before you train for the best pump, and take a pre-workout for better workouts.

- **Carbs 1 to 3 hours before:** about 30 to 60 g, like a bowl of rice, a bagel or oats with a banana. Carbs fill your muscles with glycogen, which pulls water into the muscle. That's what gives you a fuller, rounder pump and more energy for your last sets.
- **Pre-workout 20 to 30 minutes before:** the main ingredient that actually works is caffeine. About 3 to 6 mg per kg of bodyweight (roughly 200 to 300 mg for most people) improves strength and endurance. Citrulline (6 to 8 g) can add to the pump.
- **Stay safe:** keep total caffeine under 400 mg a day, counting coffee and energy drinks. Skip it within 6 hours of bed, and start with half a scoop to see how you react. Skip pre-workouts if you have a heart condition or high blood pressure.

CHAPTER 4

04 The workouts

Monday: Chest and biceps

Exercise	Sets × reps	Or swap for
Barbell bench press	3 × 6–8	Dumbbell bench press
Incline dumbbell press	3 × 6–8	Incline machine press
Weighted dips (lean forward)	3 × 6–8	Decline press
Cable fly	3 × 6–8 + drop set	Pec deck
Barbell curl	3 × 6–8	EZ-bar curl
Incline dumbbell curl	3 × 6–8 + drop set	Preacher curl

Warm-up: 2 sets of push-ups, then ramp-up sets on bench.

Tuesday: Back and triceps

Exercise	Sets × reps	Or swap for
Weighted pull-up or lat pulldown	3 × 6–8	Neutral-grip pulldown
Barbell row	3 × 6–8	T-bar row
Chest-supported row	3 × 6–8 + drop set	Seated cable row
Straight-arm pulldown	3 × 6–8	Dumbbell pullover
Close-grip bench press	3 × 6–8	Weighted dips
Overhead cable triceps extension	3 × 6–8 + drop set	EZ-bar skull crusher

Warm-up: 2 easy sets of pull-ups, then ramp-up sets on your first pull.

Shoulders and legs

Wednesday: Shoulders, abs and cooldown

Exercise	Sets × reps	Or swap for
Seated dumbbell shoulder press	3 × 6–8	Standing barbell overhead press
Machine shoulder press	3 × 6–8 + drop set	Arnold press
Dumbbell lateral raise	3 × 10–15 + drop set	Cable lateral raise
Rear delt fly	3 × 10–15	Face pull
Dumbbell shrug	3 × 6–8	Barbell shrug
Hanging leg raise	3 × 10–15	Captain's chair raise
Cable crunch	3 × 10–15	Weighted decline crunch
Ab wheel rollout	2 × 8–12	Plank, 2 × 45–60 sec

Warm-up: 2 light sets of dumbbell presses, then ramp-up sets.

Abs are the last 3 exercises. Do them after your shoulder work, then finish with your cooldown (see below).

Thursday: Legs

Exercise	Sets × reps	Or swap for
Hack squat	3 × 6–8	Back squat
Romanian deadlift	3 × 6–8	Stiff-leg deadlift
Leg press	3 × 6–8 + drop set	Bulgarian split squat
Lying leg curl	3 × 6–8	Seated leg curl
Leg extension	3 × 6–8 + drop set	Sissy squat
Standing calf raise	3 × 10–15	Seated calf raise

Warm-up: 2 sets of 10 bodyweight squats, then ramp-up sets on hack squats.

Arms, cardio and rest days

Friday: Arms and abs

Exercise	Sets × reps	Or swap for
EZ-bar curl	3 × 6–8	Barbell curl
Weighted dips (upright)	3 × 6–8	Close-grip bench press
Hammer curl	3 × 6–8	Rope hammer curl
EZ-bar skull crusher	3 × 6–8	Overhead dumbbell extension
Cable curl	3 × 6–8 **+ drop set**	Spider curl
Rope pushdown	3 × 6–8 **+ drop set**	Single-arm pushdown

Warm-up: 2 easy sets of bodyweight dips and chin-ups.

Finish with the 3 ab exercises from Wednesday.

Wednesday's cooldown

- **15 minutes on the StairMaster** at an easy, steady pace after your abs. Breathing harder, but you could still talk.
- Keep it a cooldown, not a sprint. The point is to get some cardio in and bring your heart rate down without tiring out your legs for Thursday.

No StairMaster? 15 minutes of incline walking does the same job.

EDWIN'S TIP

Abs can be hit even when they're a little sore. Ab exercises use lighter loads than heavy compound lifts, so they cause less muscle damage, and your core is built for frequent work since it's bracing to keep you upright all day. A bit of soreness is fine. If they're really sore or it hurts to brace, give them another day.

Saturday and Sunday: Rest

No lifting. A 20 to 30 minute walk outside or on the treadmill, and hit your steps.

CHAPTER 5

05 How to progress

If the weights on the bar aren't slowly going up, you're not giving your body a reason to grow. Write every set down.

Double progression

1. **Start in the range**
   Pick a weight you can lift for 6 clean reps on all 3 sets.
2. **Add reps**
   Each time you repeat the workout, try to beat last time by a rep on at least one set.
3. **Add weight**
   Once you hit 8 reps on all 3 sets, add weight: about 5 lb for upper body and 10 lb for lower body. You'll drop back to around 6 reps. Build back up and repeat.

When you stall

- Stuck on the same weight and reps for 3 sessions in a row? First check your sleep, food and protein.
- If those are good, drop the weight by about 10%, build back up, and you'll usually blow past your old best.
- Still stuck after that? Swap the exercise for the alternative in the table for a few weeks.

EDWIN'S TIP

Switch up your workout order so you don't hit the same exercise first every time. Whatever you do first gets your freshest, strongest effort, so rotating the order lets every lift get its turn at the top. It also keeps your body from settling into the exact same routine.

How to do it: every 4 weeks, move a different exercise to the top of each workout (for example, start chest day with incline press instead of bench). Keep the order the same within those 4 weeks so you can still track whether you're getting stronger.

CHAPTER 6

06 Deload weeks

Every 8 to 10 weeks, take one lighter week. It lets your joints and nervous system catch up so you come back stronger.

WHEN

8–10 wks

Or sooner if you feel beat up, sleep badly or keep stalling.

WEIGHT

30–40% less

Lighter than your normal working weight.

REPS

10–12

More reps, nowhere near failure. Keep the same exercises.

EDWIN'S TIP

Every 8 to 10 weeks I deload: I let the reps go up and the weight come down for a week. Then I come back to heavy 6 to 8s feeling fresh.

Keep your walks, steps and the StairMaster cooldown during a deload week. Keep eating normally, since recovery is the point.

CHAPTER 7

07 Making it fit your life

Only have 4 days?

Drop arm day. Add 2 sets of curls to Monday and 2 sets of triceps work to Tuesday, and move Friday's abs to the end of Monday.

Missed a day?

Don't skip that muscle for the week. Do the missed workout on Saturday, or push the week back a day and use Sunday as your only rest day.

Bulking or cutting?

The training stays the same. On a cut, aim to hold your weights on the bar. On a bulk, push to add reps and weight every week or two. Your calories decide which way the scale goes.

Your weekly checklist

- [ ] All 5 workouts and the StairMaster cooldown done and logged
- [ ] Beat last time on at least one lift each session
- [ ] Warm-up and ramp-up sets before every heavy lift
- [ ] Walk on rest days and 8,000 to 10,000 steps daily
- [ ] 7 to 9 hours of sleep most nights
- [ ] Deload booked for week 8 to 10

Want a split built for you?

At **Ascend Coaching**, a real coach with 9 years of training experience builds your training and nutrition plan 1:1, and adjusts it as you progress. Start your ascension today at Ascend Coaching.

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This guide is for general education only and is not medical advice. Lifting heavy weights carries a risk of injury. Learn proper form, use a spotter or safety pins on heavy lifts, and stop any exercise that causes pain.